

one-of-a-kind Deccan Odyssey followed in 2004, inspired by the travelling saloons of the Maratha rulers, with royal blue coaches that took their names from Maharashtrian sites and monuments. The Golden Chariot, which traverses south and south-west India, flagged off in 2008 and was followed by the Royal Rajasthan on Wheels in 2009. Each train had its own route and identity. The goal, though, was the same – to offer unforgettable, experiential travel, something ordinary passenger trains could not.

Like kings and queens

While the Palace on Wheels had always been the premier name in luxury trains, the Maharajas' Express went a step further. Inaugurated in 2010, it wove the elegance and opulence of India's kings and queens with the country's history and heritage. With guest saloons named after the nine precious gemstones or *Navratnas*, this award-winning train blended tradition with modern facilities. It travels on four different routes, taking the traveller from the hot deserts of Rajasthan to the glory of the Taj Mahal, the ghats of Varanasi, and the World Heritage Site at Khajuraho.

Operated by the Indian Railways Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC), the train won the prestigious World's Leading Luxury Train Award at the World Travel Awards for seven consecutive years, starting in 2012.

